

Episode 48: Once Upon a Time... (30) – Things That Haven't Changed Since Then *Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal*

Mid-April has passed, and the shadow of Golden Week is starting to appear. In the midst of the "Golden Week scheduling" where various departments will be properly closed during the holidays, this week is a delivery rush for magazine-related work, DVD jacket work, and various copyright materials.

But several key animation pieces haven't come up yet (bitter laugh).

For finishing, "you can't squeeze water from a stone," so we're coordinating delivery schedules with the relevant departments (bitter laugh). Such are these early summer weather days.

The other day, the *Saint Seiya: Elysion Chapter* (聖闘士星矢 エリシオン編) staff had a slightly late flower viewing—or rather, a small gathering. We rented out a soba restaurant near Oizumi Studio that the director frequents, with about 20 people centered on field staff. Miura-san, who plays "Andromeda Shun," happened to be able to participate, making it a fun gathering.

Before that gathering, we finished the art finishing meeting for *Elysion Chapter* final episode 6. And the director check for the colours of the final character designs "Athena's Cloth" and "Hades in Surplice" was also completed. That's waiting for original creator Kurumada-sensei's check.

Ah, after about 20 years, the end is finally in sight for *Saint Seiya*.

Well then.

With all meetings finished, *Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal* finally got moving. The calendar was already mid-November. We had completed the normal-time

colours for the main characters, but now—how to handle night scene colours and image scene colours?

The year was 1989. Finishing was still fully cel paint and cel animation colouring era. Unlike modern digital colouring where cel colours can be finely and subtly adjusted to match backgrounds, we had to create colours with just about 200 incomplete gradation paints.

We struggled with the limited colour count to create the basic normal-time colours and were already at our limit. From those colours, we needed to think up special colours like "slightly darker" or "add a little blue," but at this point, we were overwhelmingly short of colours.

As I wrote before, the STAC paints used by Toei Doga (now Toei Animation) were paint groups with clear, crisp saturation matching Toei Doga's child-oriented production colours. However, what I wanted for *Hana no Asuka-gumi!* 2 was desaturated, subdued intermediate colours. So while I could barely create colours for night entertainment districts with neon, I couldn't create the night colours of a snowy riverbank far from lights the way I imagined them in my head.

But I couldn't say "it's impossible." I had to manage somehow. I endlessly considered combinations with colour chart strips, repeated test colourings many times, and finally half-forcibly convinced myself "This is OK!" (bitter laugh)—using this rough technique (!) to somehow squeeze out colours.

Toei Doga's finishing work at this time had a considerable percentage of overseas outsourcing. Especially standalone OVA and theatrical works even more so. While there was still schedule, we'd outsource to studios in Manila, Philippines, but when time became really pressed, it became "animation finishing outsourcing" where we'd send key animation to Korean productions to handle animation and finishing work and return it. And again, the paint problem. Further trials (bitter laugh).

Manila studios used STAC paints, but Korean productions used Taiyo Shikisai paints. Ah, here again was STAC → Taiyo Shikisai conversion. You know, Taiyo Shikisai paints were absolutely what I wanted to use for *Asuka-gumi*! 2. "Ah, I wish I could have created colours with these paints from the start." With complex feelings, I forced conversion of colour directions I'd created with STAC colours to Taiyo colours (bitter laugh).

Anyway, cel finishing couldn't be easily changed once decided. Obviously, each colour direction had to always be in finished form. Even taking one prop, nowadays we have it coloured with "temporary colours" and change colours later, but back then it was precise colour direction decisions.

And I added varying degrees of shadow colour intensity cut by cut according to the story's excitement and tension. Scene colour directions were decided, but seeing dialogue, animation expressions, and animation quality, I wanted to add colour expressions and acting too. So it might have been self-satisfaction, but I tried various detailed directions. I was quite nervous while doing colour direction, worried about failure, then even more nervous watching the rushes (bitter laugh). This was something I'd also done in *Saint Seiya* theatrical versions, but when drama, animation, and colour combinations work together properly, good scenes feel great. Having gained confidence from this production, I've continued this style of colour direction ever since (laugh).

Time flew by, and it was year-end in a flash. However, the animation work couldn't catch up at all, so year-end delivery collapsed and carried over into the new year. At the very end of the year, after work closing finished, key animation I'd done colour direction for was sent to Korea, and Korean productions advanced the animation finishing work while Japan was on New Year holiday.

On New Year's Eve, I went to Oizumi Studio, which had only security guards and scattered people, to respond to colour direction inquiry faxes. I sent replies to several inquiries that had come in and went home just before "Red and White" started. In the new year, we put the returned cels straight into photography, forcibly approved them,

assembled the master, and delivered. I think we couldn't even properly make a first print.

Asuka-gumi! 2 was completed through all this. I was worried about the brightness matching between backgrounds and cels, but when I saw the photographed film, they blended together quite nicely, which was a relief (laugh).

But... there were still three or four "Yikes! (sweat)" failures... These were lessons for next time (bitter laugh).

That was my first OVA work.

And the OVA wave continued further. About half a year after *Asuka-gumi!* 2, at the end of summer, another OVA project came my way.

Vampire War (ヴァンパイヤー戦争). An anime adaptation of Kasai Kiyoshi's novel.

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